

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 17: Water's Embrace

Day 46 Since Awakening - 14:47

Hayami was finishing their curry when the System notification appeared in brilliant gold:

[CONGRATULATIONS!] [FOUR ELEMENTS HAVE REACHED B-RANK MASTERY]

[ARBITER CLASS ADVANCEMENT AVAILABLE]

[CLASS ADVANCEMENT: ARBITER (STAGE 3) → ARBITER (STAGE 4)]

The notification expanded, showing the progression:

[STAGE 4 BONUSES ACQUIRED:]

- +25% damage with all elemental attacks (up from 20%)
- +25% damage with all weapon attacks (up from 20%)
- +20% to all stats (up from 15%)
- Elemental Harmony bonus increased to 80% (up from 60%)
- Elemental Resistance increased to 35% (up from 25%)
- New Passive: **PRIMORDIAL RESONANCE** - Your mastered elements resonate with each other, creating spontaneous fusion effects. When using multiple B-rank elements simultaneously, they automatically enhance each other without additional mana cost.
- New Ability: **ELEMENTAL AVATAR** - Temporarily embody the pure essence of one mastered element, gaining absolute control and immunity related to that element. Duration: 2 minutes. Costs 500 Mana. Cooldown: 10 minutes.

Hayami's stats immediately shifted as the +20% multiplier recalculated across their base attributes. They felt the power settle into their body—not explosive like individual breakthroughs, but deep and fundamental.

Then the second notification appeared:

[PRIMORDIAL CYCLE ACKNOWLEDGED]

[FOUR ELEMENTS MASTERED. THE CYCLE FLOWS.]

[FIFTH ELEMENT UNLOCKED: WATER]

Water's awakening was gentle compared to the other elements. Where fire had been aggressive and wind had been expansive, water simply... flowed. It filled the spaces between other elements, connected them, gave them medium and context.

[NEW ABILITY ACQUIRED: WATER MANIPULATION (BASIC) - Rank E]

[ELEMENTS MASTERED: 4/7]

- Lightning (B-Rank) - MASTERED
- Earth (B-Rank) - MASTERED
- Wind (B-Rank) - MASTERED
- Fire (B-Rank) - MASTERED
- Water (E-Rank) - UNLOCKED

[REMAINING ELEMENTS: 2/?]

The Crown of the Arbiter pulsed on Hayami's head (hidden by Phantom Mode from everyone except the other Fylax who could sense its presence), and a fifth gemstone lit up—deep blue, like the ocean depths.

Chiyo, who was sitting directly across from Hayami, paused mid-bite. "Did you just... something changed. Your presence shifted."

"Class advancement," Hayami said quietly. "And fifth element unlocked."

"Fifth?" Himiko's eyes went wide. "You're over halfway done with the seven elements already?"

"Water just became available." Hayami could feel it now—the moisture in the air, the water vapor, the liquid in their glass, the water content in all the organic matter around them. "I'll need to train it to mastery like the others."

Shiina smiled gently. "Your progression is remarkable. Our mentors told us the Arbiter's path was the most demanding, but also the most rewarding."

"Demanding is right," Hayami muttered. "Though the System makes it easier than it would be otherwise."

Their phone buzzed. Message from Sato.

[SATO: Hey Amamiya. Got a C-rank Gate raid tomorrow if you're interested. Eclipse is running it, good team, standard difficulty. ¥250,000 payment plus loot share. You in?]

Tomorrow was actually today—Hayami checked the date. Day 46. Sato must mean later this afternoon.

[HAYAMI: Today? What time?]

[SATO: 6 PM. Chiba district. I know it's short notice, but we had someone drop out last minute and you're reliable.]

[HAYAMI: I can make it. Can I bring a friend? She's C-rank, Level 38, very capable.]

[SATO: Sure. More the merrier. Send her details and I'll add her to the roster.]

Hayami looked up at the three women. "I have a Gate raid in a few hours. Sato's Eclipse Guild operation. Anyone free?"

Himiko shook her head regretfully. "I have family stuff tonight. My brother's visiting and mom will kill me if I skip dinner."

"I promised to help at my part-time job," Shiina said apologetically. "The café is short-staffed today."

Chiyo considered, then nodded. "I'm free. I could use the experience, and I'm curious to see how you operate in a proper raid environment."

"Perfect." Hayami sent Chiyo's contact information to Sato. "Fair warning—Sato and his team have learned to just accept whatever I do without asking too many questions. It's less complicated that way."

"Sounds like my kind of arrangement," Chiyo said dryly.

They finished lunch, exchanged contact information (the four Fylax now had their own group chat labeled "Cosmic Guardians 🌟"), and made plans to train together soon. Himiko wanted to work on her newly-unlocked abilities, Shiina was curious about emotion-element synergies, and Chiyo mentioned developing advanced telepathic techniques.

But for now, Hayami and Chiyo had a Gate raid to prepare for.

17:53 - Chiba District, Gate Checkpoint

The Gate pulsed with aquamarine light—fitting, given Hayami's newly unlocked water element. It was designated C-rank, estimated Level 35-50 monsters, with a party composition of six including Hayami and Chiyo.

[GATE #CB-234: SUNKEN RUINS] [RANK: C] [ESTIMATED DIFFICULTY: C] [ELEMENT: WATER DOMINANT]

Sato was there with three Eclipse Guild members—his usual core team. When he saw Hayami approach with Chiyo, he waved them over.

"Amamiya! Right on time. And you must be Funai." He shook Chiyo's hand. "Thanks for filling in on short notice."

"Thank you for having me," Chiyo replied with perfect politeness. Hayami noticed she was already analyzing the team—reading body language, assessing capabilities, probably using light telepathy to gauge surface thoughts. The Psionic Overlord at work.

Sato pulled up his tablet. "Quick briefing. Sunken Ruins is a water-element Gate, which means lots of aquatic monsters and flooded chambers. You'll need these." He handed out breathing apparatus—magical devices that created air bubbles around the user's head. "They'll last about four hours, more than enough for a full clear."

He looked at Hayami and Chiyo. "Now, I'm going to be honest. I've worked with Amamiya three times now, and every time, they've shown capabilities way beyond what an E-rank should have. I've stopped questioning it because the results speak for themselves."

The other Eclipse members nodded. One of them—a woman named Yamada who'd been on the Glacial Wyrms King raid—spoke up. "Amamiya saved our lives on the last run. Whatever their actual power level is, we trust them."

"So," Sato continued, "I'm putting both of you on main combat rotation instead of support. Amamiya, you'll be frontline DPS. Funai, you're crowd control and tactical support. The pay for main combat is ¥250,000 each instead of ¥180,000."

Hayami and Chiyo exchanged glances. That was a significant pay increase.

"Works for us," Hayami said.

"Good. Formation: I'll tank, Takeshi and Yamada on DPS, Ren on healing, Amamiya on elemental damage, Funai on control." Sato checked his equipment. "This should be straightforward. Water monsters in a water environment means lightning and ice attacks are most effective. Anyone have those?"

"I have lightning," Hayami confirmed. "And I can work with water itself now."

"I can create psychic barriers and control enemy movements," Chiyo added. "And I have some ice techniques through telekinetic temperature manipulation."

Sato nodded approvingly. "Perfect. Let's move."

**[NOTICE: You have entered a C-Rank Gate] [Gate Name: Sunken Ruins] [Estimated Difficulty: C]
[Recommended Level: 35-50]**

The transition was jarring. One moment, solid ground. The next, they were standing on a stone platform in the middle of a vast underwater chamber. The breathing apparatus activated automatically, creating a bubble of air

around each person's head.

Everything was blue-green and dim, lit by bioluminescent coral growing on ancient stone structures. The ruins stretched in all directions—pillars, archways, buildings, all submerged and overgrown with sea life. Fish swam past, oblivious to the Hunters.

"Stay together," Sato commanded. "Visibility is poor and it's easy to get separated. First priority is clearing a path to the central temple. That's where the boss spawns."

They moved through the water with surprising ease—the breathing apparatus also provided enhanced mobility underwater. But the monsters came quickly.

[RAZOR FIN - LEVEL 37] x6

Six creatures that looked like sharks crossed with piranhas, each one two meters long with teeth designed for tearing flesh. They moved through the water faster than anything that size should be able to.

"Formation!" Sato raised his shield.

Hayami didn't wait for the monsters to reach them. "Master Lightning Strike!"

The electricity discharged into the water, and the conductive medium carried it in a spreading wave. All six Razor Fins seized up simultaneously as the current coursed through them.

[CRITICAL HIT x6!] [SUPER EFFECTIVE: WATER x LIGHTNING]

The monsters died instantly, their bodies going limp and beginning to dissolve.

[RAZOR FIN DEFEATED x6] [+8,880 EXP]

Sato stared. "That's... okay, that's new. You could do that the whole time?"

"Water conducts electricity very well," Hayami said simply. "Lightning is extremely effective in aquatic environments."

"No kidding." Sato shook his head. "This is going to be the easiest C-rank clear we've ever done."

Chiyo had been observing silently. Now she reached out with her telepathy, scanning the surrounding water for threats. "There's a larger group ahead. Twenty-plus contacts, various sizes."

"Can you sense their positions?" Sato asked.

"Precisely. I can guide us around them or help coordinate an ambush."

"Let's ambush. Amamiya, can you do that lightning thing again?"

"As many times as you need."

They moved forward with Chiyo providing real-time tactical information. Her telepathy allowed her to sense creatures through walls and water, giving the team perfect information about enemy positions.

When they encountered a school of thirty Electric Eels (ironic, given Hayami's capabilities), Chiyo used telekinesis to herd them into a tight cluster while Hayami hit them with a sustained electrical discharge that turned the water into a lethal zone.

[ELECTRIC EEL DEFEATED x30] [+14,400 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 33 → LEVEL 34]

The Eclipse team was working with unprecedented efficiency. Sato handled any monsters that got close, but between Hayami's area-of-effect lightning attacks and Chiyo's crowd control, very few enemies made it to melee range.

"This is almost unfair," Yamada commented as they cleared another chamber. "We're not even taking damage."

"Don't jinx it," Takeshi muttered.

They reached the central temple after ninety minutes of smooth progression. The building was massive—a pyramid structure covered in glowing runes. The entrance was a dark opening at the base, and Chiyo's telepathy couldn't penetrate inside.

"Boss chamber," Sato confirmed. "Everyone check equipment and mana. Amamiya, Funai—if this gets out of hand, I want you two to retreat. A smooth raid isn't worth casualties."

"Understood," Chiyo said calmly.

Hayami just nodded. They weren't worried. Four elements at B-rank, Phoenix Rebirth passive as insurance, and fighting in a water environment where their lightning was super-effective? This should be manageable.

They entered the temple.

The boss chamber was a dome-shaped room with a pool in the center. And rising from that pool was something that made even Sato take a step back.

[LEVIATHAN SPAWN - LEVEL 48] [BOSS MONSTER - C+ RANK] [HP: 65,000/65,000]

It was serpentine, easily fifteen meters long, covered in scales that shimmered with every color of the ocean. Its head was reptilian with six eyes, and when it opened its mouth, rows of crystalline teeth glinted.

"That's not a standard C-rank boss," Ren, the healer, said nervously.

"No," Sato agreed. "That's a spawn variant. Stronger than normal. Everyone stays sharp."

The Leviathan Spawn roared—a sound that resonated through the water and shook the temple walls—and attacked.

It moved like lightning through water, closing the distance to Sato in a fraction of a second. He barely got his shield up in time, and the impact sent him sliding backward.

"DPS, focus fire! Ren, barriers and healing! Crowd control, keep it off the squishies!"

Chiyo immediately began work. Her telekinesis wrapped around the Leviathan, not strong enough to restrain it fully but enough to slow its movements. Her telepathy assaulted its mind, creating confusion and disorientation.

Hayami activated all four of their B-rank domains simultaneously—something only possible with Primordial Resonance.

"Lightning Domain! Earth Domain! Wind Domain! Inferno Domain!"

Four overlapping spheres of elemental energy exploded into existence. The temple chamber became a battlefield where every element was weaponized. Lightning crackled through the water. Stone constructs rose and fell. Wind created currents and whirlpools. Fire somehow burned underwater, superheating the liquid into steam pockets.

The Leviathan Spawn found itself fighting in an environment where everything was hostile.

[LEVIATHAN SPAWN HP: 65,000 → 58,700]

Hayami drew the Twin Fangs—Storm Fang in their right hand, Terra Fang in their left. They activated Wind Stride and Thunder Flash, moving through the water like they were flying, and struck the Leviathan with both daggers simultaneously.

"Elemental Twin Strike!"

Storm Fang channeled lightning and wind. Terra Fang channeled earth and fire. The combination attack hit the Leviathan with four elements at once, and the Primordial Resonance passive made them interact and amplify each other automatically.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [ELEMENTAL FUSION DAMAGE!] [LEVIATHAN SPAWN HP: 58,700 → 46,300]

Over twelve thousand damage in one hit. The Leviathan shrieked and thrashed, its tail sweeping toward Hayami.

Chiyo reacted instantly. A telekinetic barrier appeared between Hayami and the tail, absorbing the impact. "I've got your back!"

"Thanks!" Hayami used Thunder Flash again, appearing above the Leviathan's head, and drove both daggers into its skull while channeling Master Lightning Strike through the blades.

The Eclipse team was doing their part—Sato held aggro when possible, Takeshi and Yamada struck at weak points, Ren kept everyone topped off with healing and barriers. But it was clear that Hayami and Chiyo were carrying the offense.

The Leviathan adapted, diving deep into the pool to escape the elemental domains. But Hayami simply followed, their newly awakened water sense allowing them to track its movements perfectly.

"Plasma Wave!"

The superheated plasma spread through the water like an expanding sphere of death. The Leviathan Spawn tried to dodge but was too large, too slow. The plasma caught it along its entire length.

[LEVIATHAN SPAWN HP: 46,300 → 32,800]

Chiyo added her own attack—a telepathic assault that targeted the Leviathan's primitive mind directly.

"Cognitive Cascade!"

The monster's movements became erratic, uncoordinated. It was attacking its own reflection, seeing threats that didn't exist, completely lost in a prison of its own confused consciousness.

Hayami used the opening to launch everything they had.

"Master Stone Lance! Thunder Flash! Plasma Burst! Cyclone!"

Four massive attacks in rapid succession. The stone lance punched through scales. The lightning strike overloaded its nervous system. The plasma burst melted flesh. The cyclone trapped it in a whirlpool it couldn't escape.

[LEVIATHAN SPAWN HP: 32,800 → 11,200]

"Finish it!" Sato called out.

Hayami planted their feet on the temple floor, activated Earthborn to root themselves immovably, and channeled the full might of four B-rank elements into a single technique.

"PRIMORDIAL CONVERGENCE!"

Lightning, earth, wind, and fire—all four elements compressed into a spear of pure elemental fury, launched with the full force of Hayami's 285 Intelligence stat and all their equipment bonuses stacking multiplicatively.

The attack struck the Leviathan Spawn center-mass and simply tore through it. The monster's body split, its HP dropped to zero, and it dissolved into mist with one final, mournful cry.

[LEVIATHAN SPAWN DEFEATED] [+12,100 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 34 → LEVEL 35]

[RAID COMPLETE]

Silence filled the temple chamber except for the sound of water settling. The Eclipse team stood in various states of shock.

Yamada was the first to speak. "That was a C+ boss. We just cleared a C+ boss in under five minutes."

"Because Amamiya hit it with the equivalent of a small tactical nuke," Takeshi added. "That last attack... what even was that?"

"Elemental fusion technique," Hayami said, deliberately vague. "Combines multiple elements into one strike."

Sato walked over, and for a moment Hayami thought he was going to demand answers. Instead, he just laughed.

"You know what? I don't care anymore. I don't care how an E-rank does what you do. I don't care if you're secretly an S-rank in disguise. You're reliable, you're effective, and you make our jobs easier." He extended his hand. "Welcome to Eclipse as a permanent contractor. Whatever your rate is, we'll match it."

"I'm flattered, but I prefer independent work," Hayami said, shaking his hand. "But I'll keep taking your raid invitations."

"Fair enough." Sato turned to Chiyo. "And you, Funai. Telepathic crowd control and tactical awareness? That's exactly what Eclipse needs. If you're ever looking for steady work, call me."

"I'll consider it," Chiyo replied diplomatically.

They harvested the boss loot—high-grade water crystals, rare scales, and a B-rank skill book for Advanced Water Manipulation that Hayami immediately absorbed.

[WATER MANIPULATION: E-RANK → C-RANK (0%)]

The knowledge flooded in, jumping their water element two full ranks instantly. The skill book was apparently designed for advanced users, assuming baseline competency that Hayami's B-rank elemental understanding provided.

Payment was distributed: ¥250,000 each as promised, plus loot shares that added another ¥95,000.

[TOTAL PAYMENT: ¥345,000]

As they exited the Gate, Chiyo spoke quietly. "That was impressive. Your elemental control and fusion techniques are far beyond what I expected."

"You weren't bad yourself. That telepathic crowd control saved us from taking any real damage."

"We work well together." Chiyo's expression was thoughtful. "The Fylax are meant to complement each other, aren't they? Your elemental versatility, my mental control, Shiina's emotional manipulation, Himiko's adaptability. Each of us covers different aspects of combat and support."

"Probably intentional design by whoever chose us," Hayami agreed. "Speaking of which, want to grab dinner? I'm starving, and we should probably coordinate our schedules for future training sessions."

"Dinner sounds good. I know a place."

They walked together through the evening streets, two Fylax who'd just cleared a C+ boss with casual efficiency, discussing training schedules and potential team compositions like it was normal.

Hayami's phone buzzed with messages:

[HIMIKO: How was the raid??? Did you and Chiyo bond??? Tell me everything!!!]

[SHIINA: I hope the Gate went well. Stay safe. ]

[SATO: Seriously, if you change your mind about Eclipse, the offer stands. You're the most reliable contractor we have.]

Forty-six days since Awakening. Level 35. Five elements unlocked, four at B-rank. Stage 4 Arbiter. Three Fylax allies. Two professional Hunter contacts. Financial security. And a cosmic destiny that was slowly becoming clearer.

The grind continued. But with allies, purpose, and direction.

Not bad for someone who'd been a convenience store clerk six and a half weeks ago.

[END OF CHAPTER 17]

[UPDATED STATUS SUMMARY]

[LEVEL: 35] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 4)] [DAYS SINCE AWAKENING: 46]

[ELEMENTS]

- Lightning Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Earth Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Wind Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Fire Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Water Manipulation (C-Rank 0%) - UNLOCKED

- Metal Manipulation (C-Rank 0%) - Earth Branch

[STATS] (with equipment and Stage 4 bonuses)

- Strength: 242 (+20% class bonus now)
- Agility: 322 (S-rank threshold reached!)
- Vitality: 223
- Intelligence: 342 (high S-rank)
- Sense: 245
- Mana: 3,920/3,920

[NEW STAGE 4 BONUSES]

- +25% all elemental damage
- +25% all weapon damage
- +20% to all stats
- 80% Elemental Harmony bonus
- 35% Elemental Resistance
- Primordial Resonance (auto-fusion effects)
- Elemental Avatar ability

[RAID RESULTS]

- Payment: ¥345,000
- Two level-ups (33 → 35)
- Water Manipulation jumped to C-rank
- Eclipse permanent contractor offer
- Successful partnership with Chiyo demonstrated

[FINANCES]

- Current Balance: ¥1,842,000
- Approaching ¥2 million savings

[NEXT OBJECTIVES]

- Master Water element to B-rank
- Unlock final 2 elements (Ice, Nature)
- Continue building Fylax team dynamics
- Find the Walker and Dancer
- Maintain daily quest streak (25 days)

[COMBAT CAPABILITIES]

- Four-domain simultaneous activation
- Quad-element fusion strikes
- S-rank Agility (322)
- S-rank Intelligence (342)
- Phoenix Rebirth resurrection
- Twin Fang legendary weapons